

How to land the first customer.

A 90-day operating plan for Alphard's first three paid design partners — sales, marketing, and GTM motions, with an honest list of what to hold off on.

STAGE	HORIZON	GOAL	FOUNDER SPLIT
Pre-revenue Design partner hunt	90 days to first paid pilot	3 paid pilots at \$2–4K/mo each	~80% on GTM ~20% on product

Compress the funnel. Skip every step that requires brand or scale.

You are pre-revenue with a working prototype. You do not have a brand, customer logos, or case studies. You have three asymmetric advantages, and the playbook below is built to weaponise each of them.

1

POLISHED
PERSONALISED
SANDBOX

2

FOUNDER POV ON
A NAMED,
EXPENSIVE
PROBLEM

3

SPEED — FASTER
THAN ANY
INCUMBENT CAN
SHIP

90d

CHEQUE ON THE
TABLE OR RE-
DIAGNOSE

THE THESIS BEHIND THIS DOCUMENT

Most early founders die from doing too many things, not from doing the wrong thing. This is a deliberate set of bets. The "hold off" list at the back is as important as the "do" list at the front. If you only follow one section, follow that one.

ICP — narrow on purpose

Your demo looks like enterprise SaaS. Don't waste calls on PLG companies or single-product startups. The cost of saying no to off-ICP prospects is zero. The cost of saying yes is a wasted month.

FILTER	YES	NO
Industry	Multi-product B2B SaaS	PLG, consumer, single-product startups
Revenue	\$20M–\$200M ARR	< \$20M (no AM team) or > \$300M (procurement nightmare)
Team	50–200 AMs (or CSMs doing expansion)	< 20 (founder still owns accounts)
Geography	US or UK HQ	EU/APAC for now (timezone friction)
Catalog	3+ products / SKUs	Single-product (white-space loses meaning)
Pain marker	NRR < 110% in last public quarter	NRR > 130% (they don't feel pain)

Hot prospect signals

Accounts with at least one of these jump to the top of the list:

- Just had a RIF that consolidated AM/CSM into one team

- Just hired a Head of Customer / VP Account Management (90-day mandate window)
- Publicly missed NRR target last quarter
- Recently raised Series C/D — pressure to grow expansion ARR
- Posted a job for "Director of Revenue Operations — Customer" or similar

ANTI-ICP — SAY NO

Do not chase F500. Do not chase pre-Series-B. Do not chase companies whose AM team is < 10 people. You will burn three months and learn nothing.

The wedge — your sandbox is the entire GTM motion

Internalise this. Most early-stage SaaS pitches end at "hop on a 30-minute call." Yours ends at "here's a sandbox with your company name on it that you can play with for a week."

WHY THIS WORKS	OPERATING IMPLICATION
Removes calendar friction. Champions can play on their own time without pulling their boss in.	Every CTA in outreach ends with a sandbox offer — never a Calendly link.
Beats demo theatre. They control the clicks. They become your internal seller.	Personalise every sandbox. Three accounts that mirror their real customer base, researched in advance.
Creates an "oh, this actually works" moment that no live demo replicates.	Send a 90-second Loom with every sandbox — re-record per prospect, never reuse.
Lets you stay on offence. While they explore, you're already prospecting the next ten.	Day-3 PostHog-triggered nurture. Day-7 wrap email.

Founder-led, sandbox-first.

No SDRs, no AEs, no closers. Until you have personally closed five deals, you cannot teach the motion to anyone — so don't try.

The 7-step sequence

1. **Identify** — 10 net-new ICP prospects per week, hand-picked from LinkedIn Sales Navigator
2. **Warm up** — comment thoughtfully on 2–3 of their posts before reaching out. Never a generic "great post"
3. **Reach out** — LinkedIn DM > cold email; 80–120 words; one specific observation about their company; sandbox offer at the end
4. **Personalised sandbox** — spin it up, send a 90-second Loom of you walking them through their sandbox
5. **Trial week** — intervene at day 3 if they haven't logged in; share a usage screenshot at day 5
6. **"What would it take" call** — 30 min. Not a demo. They've seen the demo. This is "tell me what would have to be true for you to write a \$24K cheque?"
7. **Pilot proposal** — 6-month paid pilot, \$2–4K/mo, success criteria pre-agreed in writing

The cold DM template

LINKEDIN DM · 80–120 WORDS

Hey [Name] — saw your post on [specific thing]. The bit about [specific detail] mirrors what I keep hearing from VPs running expansion at companies your size: the AMs are working off a spreadsheet and a hunch.

I'm building Alphard — it ranks every account in your book daily by expansion heat and tells your AMs which one to work first, with reasons. Not another CS platform.

Easier to show than describe. If I sent you a 7-day sandbox with your company name on it and three accounts that look like your real ones — would you click around for ten minutes and tell me if it's any good? No call required.

— Pragyan

WHY THIS TEMPLATE WORKS

- Names a specific observation (not "I noticed your company is great")
- Anchors the pain in their language
- States what Alphard is *not* (CS platform) before what it is
- Asks for ten minutes of clicks, not a meeting

- Founder voice, not corporate

Pricing for the first five customers

List price	Don't publish one yet. Quote per deal.
Pilot price	\$2,000–\$4,000/month, 6-month minimum, billed monthly
Annual ACV target	\$24K–\$48K
Discounting	You are the founder; discount whatever you need. The cheque is the validation, not the revenue.

A BLUNT TRUTH ABOUT EARLY PRICING

You will lose money on these deals after support and integration time. That is fine. You are buying signal, case studies, and product feedback at below market rate. The first ten customers exist to teach you what to sell to the next hundred.

Pull, not push. Founder voice, not brand voice.

Every dollar that goes to "marketing" before you have 10 paid customers is a dollar that should have gone to outbound time. The exception is content — content compounds, ads don't.

Channels in priority order

1. LINKEDIN PERSONAL BRAND — PRIMARY

- 3 posts per week, all on expansion / AM ops / multi-product growth
- Show your thinking, not your product. Product mentions are < 1 in 5 posts
- Comment thoughtfully on every post by your top 50 ICP prospects within 48 hours
- Reply to every DM personally within 4 working hours
- **Goal:** become the LinkedIn voice on AM expansion within 6 months

2. LONG-FORM ESSAY EVERY 2 WEEKS — SECONDARY

- 1,000–1,500 words on a specific expansion-ops problem
- Cross-post: LinkedIn article → blog → email to friendly readers (curate a list of 50–100 names you've met)
- Light SEO: target 5–10 specific phrases a year, not a content factory

3. THE PRODUCT IS THE MARKETING — ALWAYS-ON

- Every demo URL, every Loom, every animated screenshot in the app is shareable
- Ask every sandbox user "would you mind if I shared an anonymised screenshot of your trial?" — most say yes
- Build a "show, don't tell" library you draw from in posts

4. PODCAST GUEST SPOTS — ONE PER MONTH

- Get on AM-adjacent and CS-adjacent shows. Not the giants — the niche ones (50–200 listeners is fine if they are all your ICP)
- Pitch with the angle, not the product: "I have a contrarian take on why CS platforms fail AMs" beats "I built an AM tool, want to talk about it?"

5. HAND-PICKED NEWSLETTER SPONSORSHIPS — SELECTIVE

- \$500–\$2,000 per placement
- Only if the newsletter has < 50K subs and audience is clean ICP
- Test 3 placements before scaling spend on any one
- Avoid "RevOps" / "SaaS" general lists — too broad

Content themes that compound

THEME	EXAMPLE ANGLE	WHY IT WORKS
Positioning	"Why your CSM tool isn't helping your AMs"	Names the incumbent, gives them a frame
POV	"The expansion playbook nobody writes down"	Founder-as-thinker, not founder-as-vendor
Build-in-public	"We rebuilt the AM dashboard from scratch — what we learned"	Product without selling
Data	"I read every public NRR disclosure this quarter — the pattern"	Earned authority, sharable, evergreen
Manifestos	"Expansion is a pipeline, not a relationship"	Anchors your category

The funnel maths and the tooling.

Everything below assumes 200 hand-picked ICP prospects worked over 60–90 days. The numbers are what's realistic for founder-led pre-revenue sales — not what's polished in a board deck.

The funnel

01	Cold contact DM or email sent to an ICP prospect	—
02	Engaged Replied, opened sandbox, or watched the Loom	8–12%
03	Sandbox active Logged in 2+ times in trial week	50%
04	Pilot conversation 30-minute call booked	60%
05	Pilot signed \$2K+/mo paid pilot live	30–50%

THE MATH

200 cold prospects → ~20 engaged → ~10 active sandboxes → ~6 calls → 2–3 paid pilots over 60–90 days. If your numbers are dramatically worse, the ICP is wrong, the wedge is broken, or the outreach copy is off — diagnose in that order.

Where pipeline comes from

60%

OUTBOUND
LINKEDIN DMS

25%

INBOUND FROM
LINKEDIN
CONTENT

15%

WARM INTROS
(ASK EVERYONE)

0%

PAID ADS (NOT
YET)

Tooling — cheap and sufficient

NEED	TOOL	COST
CRM	Notion or HubSpot free tier	\$0
Outreach sequencer	Lemlist / Smartlead — pick one	\$50–100/mo
Lead source	LinkedIn Sales Navigator	\$99/mo
Analytics	PostHog (already shipped)	\$0
Email tracking	Streak or Mixmax in Gmail	\$0–15/mo

Total stack cost: under \$300/mo. If yours is more, you are over-engineered.

90-day execution plan

Three phases, each with a single primary goal. Don't blur them — finish each phase's bar before moving on. If you don't have one paid pilot by day 60, the ICP is wrong. Re-diagnose, do not just push harder.

DAYS 1–30

Foundation

Goal: 3 sandbox trials, 1 pilot conversation

- 200-contact ICP list built
- Sandbox flow audited end-to-end
- Day-3 and day-7 nurture emails written and triggered
- 3 LinkedIn essays published
- Cadence locked: 3 posts/week
- 50 cold DMs sent
- One advisor asked for 3 specific intros

DAYS 31–60

Volume

Goal: 10 sandbox trials, 5 pilot conversations, 1 pilot signed

- 100 more cold DMs (50/week)
- Weekly LinkedIn cadence reliable
- First podcast booked
- First pilot proposal sent
- Day-30 retro: which channel converted?
- CD call with every sandbox user, even non-engagers

DAYS 61–90

Conversion

Goal: 3 paid pilots live

- Optimise highest-converting channel; cut others
- First pilot live with weekly check-ins
- Case study draft started (structure before results)
- First public talking point about a customer
- Decision point: 0 pilots by day 60 = re-diagnose ICP

Hold off on these — and why

The hardest part of early-stage GTM is saying no to obvious-looking moves. Each row below is a thing a "real" company does. You are not a real company yet. Be honest about it.

HOLD	WHY	TRIGGER TO REVISIT
Hiring AEs / SDRs	You can't teach a motion you haven't validated	After you've personally closed 5 deals
Paid Google / LinkedIn ads	Burns cash with no signal pre-PMF	After you have a known CAC and LTV
SOC 2	\$20–40K and 6 months; deals don't block on it yet	First deal that explicitly blocks on it
Self-serve / Stripe checkout	You need conversations to learn the buyer	After 10 customers with the same buying motion
Conference booths	Booth + travel + opportunity cost > lead value	When you can sponsor with a customer logo
Brand redesign	Current brand is fine; iterate after revenue	After 10 customers tell you it looks dated
PR firm	No story to tell yet; PR works post-milestone	After Series A or first lighthouse customer
Pre-built integrations beyond Salesforce + Gong	Builds debt before product-market fit	When a deal explicitly requires it
Partner programme	Pre-revenue; no partner cares	After \$1M ARR
G2 / Capterra listings	Empty profiles hurt	When you have 5 real reviews to seed
ABM platforms (6sense, Demandbase)	Useless under \$5M ARR	After scaling outbound past founder bandwidth
Head of Marketing hire	You are the marketing	After Series A
Multi-channel attribution	Premature; you have 200 prospects	After 1,000 leads/month
Your own webinars	No audience yet	Co-host after 50 customers

Metrics that matter — and ones to ignore

Track weekly

1. New sandbox trials this week
2. Pilot conversations booked this week
3. Paid pilots live (cumulative)
4. Qualitative replies — every "no" with a reason is data; every "yes" is a story
5. Cycle time: first contact → pilot signed

Ignore until further notice

1. Website traffic
2. Email open rates (broken since iOS 15 anyway)
3. LinkedIn impressions (vanity unless they convert)
4. MQL / SQL labels (you have neither yet)
5. CAC (no data) and burn multiple (no revenue)
6. ARR projections beyond 90 days

What works best · what to hold off on

DO What works best

1. **Personalised sandbox** beats scheduled demo call. Always.
2. **LinkedIn DM** beats cold email for senior B2B SaaS buyers.
3. **Founder voice** beats brand voice until you have brand to speak with.
4. **Hand-picked 200** beats sprayed 5,000. Quality of list > volume.
5. **One signed pilot** beats ten "great meetings." A meeting is not progress.

DON'T What to hold off on

1. Don't hire sales until you've sold yourself.
2. Don't spend on paid until you know LTV.
3. Don't build certifications until a deal blocks.
4. Don't add channels you can't measure.
5. Don't ship integrations on spec — ship them on demand.

Final word

THE BIGGEST RISK AT THIS STAGE

It's not picking the wrong channel. It's spreading thin across five channels and getting signal from none. Pick LinkedIn-DM-into-sandbox as the only motion for the next 90 days. If it works, scale it. If it doesn't, you'll know in 60 days, not 6 months — and you can change one variable at a time.

Get the first cheque. Everything else is a downstream problem.

